

M8 Learning Plan

A 9-week structured plan for M8 producers who want to ship tracks again.

A note before you read

I built this for myself with Claude (Anthropic) after realizing I had a drawer full of trackers, grooveboxes and samplers but no recent finished tracks. The diagnosis was simple: I kept buying new gear to spark ideas instead of going deeper into the tools that already worked for me. M8 was the one that produced finished work in the past, so I built a plan to rebuild fluency, close my real gaps (instrument tables, sound design, arrangement, mixing, mastering), and ship tracks again.

Sharing it here in case it helps anyone else stuck in the same loop. It's generalized — no personal references — but the structure and the specific corrections are real. Take what's useful, ignore the rest.

What this plan covers: M8 technique, synthesis fundamentals, arrangement, on-device mixing, on-device finalization, optional Ableton post-production. Verified against M8 firmware 6.5.2.

Time commitment: 2–3 focused sessions per week, ~60 min each. ~20 hours total over Weeks 1–9. Optional Week 10 adds ~3 hours.

Outcome: Two shipped tracks in ~9 weeks. After that, ~4–5 weeks per release-ready track sustainably.

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Overview & operating principles

9-week plan (+ optional Week 10) to rebuild fluency on the Dirtywave M8, ship two tracks, and close five specific gaps: instrument tables, sound design, arrangement, mixing, mastering.

A note before you read

This plan was built for a producer who realized they had a drawer full of trackers, grooveboxes and samplers but no recent finished tracks. The diagnosis was simple: they kept buying new gear to spark ideas instead of going deeper into the tools that already worked. M8 was the one device that produced finished work in the past, so they built a plan to rebuild fluency, close their real gaps, and ship tracks again.

It's been generalized for sharing. The structure and the specific corrections are real. Take what's useful, ignore the rest.

Why this plan exists

M8 is the only standalone device with a proven finishing track record. Re-entry friction is lower than learning anything new. Once M8 fluency is back, other gear becomes the next project.

Five gaps being targeted

- **Instrument tables** — feel cryptic, blocked deeper use of M8
- **Sound design** — over-reliance on presets, no personal sonic identity
- **Arrangement** — tracks meander, don't "arrive"
- **Mixing** — elements fight, mix doesn't translate across systems
- **Mastering / finalization** — raw renders, no polish, can't share confidently

The first three are connected: they're all *shaping how sound changes over time* at different scales — milliseconds (envelopes), bars (tables/automation), minutes (arrangement). Same skill, three views.

Mixing is the fourth axis: *shaping how sounds relate to each other in frequency and space*. Mastering is the final polish that lets the result translate.

Operating principles

- **Two projects, two finishes.** Project 1 (Weeks 1–6) uses presets and lets you focus on technique. Project 2 (Weeks 7–9) uses your own instruments and applies everything.
- **Render every week, even when bad.** No "I'll polish later." Bounce, save, move on.
- **Three threads per week:** M8 technique + synthesis fundamental + arrangement principle (Phase 1). Mix and finalization replace technique threads in Phase 2 onwards.
- **Cumulative, not replacement.** Each week's deliverable builds on the previous week's project.
- **Stuck? Copy.** Reverse-engineer patches from Dirtywave Discord / YouTube. Faster than from-scratch.

- **No new gear, no comparisons.** M8 only for the duration. Optional Week 10 brings Ableton in for post-production only.

Cadence

2–3 focused sessions per week, ~60 min each. ~20 hours total over Weeks 1–9. Optional Week 10 adds ~3 hours.

Realistic timing expectation:

- ~6 weeks to first release-ready track (Project 1)
- ~3 weeks for Project 2 after the library is built
- After the plan ends: 4–5 weeks per release-ready track is sustainable cadence. Some tracks faster, some slower. The number that matters is "finished," not "every X weeks."

Anti-burnout rules

- Miss a week → **don't catch up.** Continue from the calendar. Catching up kills plans.
- Stale week → do it dirty and ugly. Bad output > no output.
- No comparing output to YouTube tracks. Reference for *learning*, not *judging*.
- After Week 9 → **deliberate week off.** Active rest. No M8, no other gear, no browsing.

Weekly structure

Three phases. Each week is an epic with granular tasks and a clear deliverable.

Phase 1 — Learn (Weeks 1–4): pure technique, no finishing pressure

- Week 1 — Re-entry
- Week 2 — LFO to filter + envelopes
- Week 3 — Pitch slides, Tracking, filters
- Week 4 — Retrigger, arpeggios, LFO concept

Phase 2 — Apply (Weeks 5–7): Project 1 finish + library

- Week 5 — Mix Project 1 (dedicated mix week, no new technique)
- Week 6 — Finalize and ship Project 1
- Week 7 — Starter instrument library (no track, recovery week)

Phase 3 — Polish (Weeks 8–9): Project 2

- Week 8 — Build Project 2 (own instruments, all techniques)
- Week 9 — Finalize and ship Project 2 (Scope A)

Optional Week 10: Scope B Ableton mix + master pass on Project 2.

Plus three standalone reference pages:

- Mixing Reference — used Week 5 onwards for balancing tracks

- Finalization Reference — used Week 6, 9, 10 for mastering after mixing
- Generative Toolkit Reference — six generative techniques (LFO shapes, phrase randomization, table TIC modes, Hypersynth, table-as-arpeggiator) woven into Weeks 2, 4, 7, 8

Mixing and mastering

Finishing a track means making it sound finished, not just rendering raw. Two stages, two reference pages, separate weeks:

Mixing (balance the elements against each other)

- **Scope A (on-device M8 only):** default. Mixer View, per-instrument EQ, send levels, TRIG-based side-chain. Used Week 5 (Project 1), Week 8 (Project 2).
- **Scope B (render stems to Ableton):** optional. Used Week 10 only.

Mastering / finalization (polish the mixed track)

- **Scope A (on-device M8 only):** default. Built-in EQ, OTT, limiter, soft-clip via Mixer and Limiter & Mix Scope views. Used Week 6 (Project 1), Week 9 (Project 2).
- **Scope B (optional Ableton pass):** for tracks you'll share or publish. Used Week 10 only.

Always mix before you master. Mastering can't fix a bad mix. Both stages are time-boxed: 60 min max per session.

What this plan deliberately does NOT cover

- MIDI out to external gear
- Sampling deep-dives
- Mixing/mastering perfectionism (render at -6dB peak, done)
- Reading the manual cover-to-cover (already did, didn't help)

Resources

Primary references

- [M8 Operation Manual v6.5.2](#) — your bible. Each week links to specific sections by page number.
- [The M8 Companion](#) — community-written structured guide, often clearer than the manual.
- [Printable Shortcut Guide](#) — print once, keep next to the M8.

Video references

- [Dirtywave YouTube channel](#) — official, demos and walkthroughs.
- [Dirtywave M8 Tutorials playlist](#) — technique-specific videos.

Tools

- [M8 table editor](#) — browser-based table builder, removes hex friction while learning.
- [ChordMate](#) — convert chords to hex.

- [DigiChain](#) — builds M8-compatible drum chains with slice markers.

Sound design / instruments to study

- [Community Starter Pack](#) — ready-made instruments to reverse-engineer.
- [laamaa instruments](#) — high-quality community instrument bank.
- [laamaa — seven weeks](#) — album with M8 source files included.

Community

- [Dirtywave Discord](#)
- [r/Dirtywave](#)
- [Patchstorage M8 patches](#)

Awesome M8

The full curated list this plan draws from: github.com/v3rm0n/awesome-m8

How to use these

Don't read the manual end-to-end. Each week task references the relevant manual page. When stuck, check the Companion or search the Dirtywave playlist for the specific technique.

Week 1 — Re-entry

Goal: Remove cold-start friction. Rebuild muscle memory. No new techniques — prove the device still works for you. **Mindset:** Deliberately low bar. Success = boot it, use it, render something. **Manual references:** Getting Started (p.5), Navigation (p.6), Global Key Shortcuts (p.7), Loading a Demo Song (p.9), Song View (p.10), Chain View (p.12), Phrase View (p.14), Render View (p.47).

Thread 1: M8 technique — Re-entry

Boot and recall

- Charge M8 if battery low. Boot with power button (right side, 1 sec hold). Reference: Powering Up, p.3.
- In Song View: Project View is above Song View — navigate [SHIFT]+[UP] from Song View, choose LOAD, [EDIT] to enter file browser. Reference: Loading a Demo Song, p.9.
- Load one of your previously finished tracks (or a demo if starting fresh).
- Press [SHIFT]+[PLAY] to play the whole song. Listen all the way through.
- Navigate around while it plays: [SHIFT]+[DIRECTION] moves between views (mini-map bottom right shows where you are).
- Open one of its instruments: from Phrase View, position cursor on instrument column (I), press [SHIFT]+[RIGHT] to jump to Instrument View. Look at settings. **Don't edit.**

Start Project 1

- In Project View, choose NEW (or load a fresh song slot). Name it Project1 in the project settings.
- Build a 4-bar loop using 3 tracks:
 - Track 1: drums. **The M8 has no "kit" concept** — a Sampler instrument loads ONE sample file and plays it back. Use three separate Sampler instruments:
 - Instrument 00: Sampler, SAMPLE = a kick .wav from /Samples/ (one-shot, not a sliced chain)
 - Instrument 01: Sampler, SAMPLE = a snare .wav
 - Instrument 02: Sampler, SAMPLE = a hi-hat .wav
 - In Phrase View on the drum track, vary the I column per row to switch which sound plays (e.g. kick on row 00, snare on row 04, hat on rows 02/06). Note value stays constant (e.g. C-4).
 - **Note on sliced kit files:** if you load a multi-hit drum chain into one Sampler with SLICE 000FF, it just plays the whole file pitched by note — not what you want. To trigger slices chromatically you need slice markers (via the Sampler's AUTO or SILENCE slicing modes) plus a non-zero SLICE parameter in Instrument View. **Skip this for Week 1** — it's covered in Week 7.
 - Track 2: bass (use Macrosynth, default model — pick a low note, around C-3)
 - Track 3: melodic (use Macrosynth or wavsynth preset — higher note, around C-5)

- In Phrase View: enter notes in column N, leave velocity V at default 64, set instrument I to your instrument number.
- **Presets only.** No instrument editing this week.
- Save the project: Project View → SAVE.

Thread 2: Synthesis fundamental — Oscillators

Goal: train your ears to recognize the 5 fundamental wave shapes.

- Open an empty instrument slot, set TYPE to Wavsynth (Wavsynth view, manual p.50).
- In Wavsynth, the SHAPE parameter cycles through wave types. Reference: Wavsynth Wave Table Index, p.82.
- Listen to each in isolation. Set envelope to default (Instrument Modulation View → MOD1 = AHD ENVELOPE with default values).
- Hit [EDIT]+[PLAY] to preview the instrument at each shape change.
- Mental notes (no need to write):
 - **Sine** — pure, sub-frequency, no harmonics
 - **Sawtooth** — bright, all harmonics, classic synth bass/lead
 - **Square** — hollow, only odd harmonics, "clarinet-y"
 - **Triangle** — mellow, mostly fundamental + weak harmonics
 - **Noise** — non-pitched, used for hats/snare/sweeps

Thread 3: Arrangement principle — Identifying tension and release

Goal: train your ear to spot what makes electronic tracks "arrive."

- Pick 2–3 tracks you love (electronic, any genre — preferably tracks in your taste range).
- Listen to each once, fully. Identify the **single moment** everything was building toward.
- Note: it might be the full drop, a melodic entrance, a sudden silence, or a sound finally being unmuted. Could even be a *negative* arrival (everything drops out).
- Don't try to write one yet. Just notice.
- Reference (optional listening): [laamaa - seven weeks](#) — M8 album with source files. Notice how each track has a clear arc.

■ Deliverable

- Extend the 4-bar phrase into a 32-bar arrangement using **Chain View**. Each chain holds up to 16 phrases (manual p.12).
- Add basic dynamics: mute/unmute tracks across sections. Mute current track with [OPTION]+[SHIFT] from Song View.
- Render: navigate to Render View (manual p.47) and render the song to WAV.

- Save the WAV with today's date in the filename.

Week 2 — LFO to filter (modulation slots + tables)

Goal: Crack the modulation system. Learn the difference between **modulation slots** (instrument-level, the cleanest way to do LFOs) and **tables** (per-step automation, for things slots can't do).

The big realization for this week: the M8 has 4 dedicated modulation slots per instrument before you even touch tables. For "LFO to filter," the modulation slot is usually the right tool. Tables are for *stepped* automation, arpeggios, multi-stage envelopes — things slots can't do cleanly.

Manual references: Instrument Modulation View (p.18), Modulation Types: LFO (p.20–21), Table View (p.24), Macrosynth (p.52), Effect Command Help View (p.48).

Thread 1: M8 technique — LFO to filter, two ways

Method A: Modulation slot (recommended for LFO → filter)

This is the clean, idiomatic way.

- Open the bass instrument in Project 1. Make sure TYPE is Macrosynth (manual p.52).
- In Instrument View, the Macrosynth has a FILTER parameter section with CUTOFF and RES. Set CUTOFF to a low-ish value (~40) so there's room for the LFO to open it.
- Navigate [SHIFT]+[UP] from Instrument View → Instrument Modulation View (p.18).
- You'll see 4 modulation slots (MOD1–MOD4). Each has TYPE, DEST, and parameters.
- Configure MOD1:
 - MOD1 type: LFO
 - DEST: FILTER CUTOFF (cycle with [EDIT]+[DIRECTION])
 - AMT: try 40 to start (range 00–FF). This is modulation depth.
 - OSC: TRI (triangle — smooth, classic LFO shape). Other shapes listed manual p.21.
 - TRIG: FREE (loops continuously, doesn't reset per note). Options: FREE/RETRIG/HOLD/ONCE.
 - FREQ: 08 (a value in 16th-note steps when OSC is non-tick).
- Preview with [EDIT]+[PLAY]. Hear the filter slowly open and close.
- Experiment: change FREQ to 04 (faster), 10 (slower). Change OSC to SIN (smoother), SQU DN (gated). Change AMT to taste.

Generative bonus: RANDOM and DRUNK shapes

See *Generative Toolkit Reference* for full context.

- On the same instrument, change OSC to DRUNK. Hear: filter wanders organically, never repeats exactly.
- Change OSC to RANDOM. Hear: stepped, jumpy values per cycle.

- Both are documented LFO shapes (manual p.21).
- **Use case:** any time a parameter should feel alive rather than mechanical. Pads, evolving textures, sound design.
- **Watch out:** AMT too high = chaotic. Subtle (20–40) is usually better than dramatic.

Method B: Table-based "manual LFO" (when you need stepped/synced control)

This is the table approach. Use when you want each step of the phrase to have an explicit filter value — not smooth automation.

- Stay on the bass instrument. Navigate [SHIFT]+[RIGHT] from Instrument View → Table View (manual p.24).
- The table has 16 rows with N (transpose), V (volume), and 3 FX columns.
- To open the FX command helper: position cursor on an FX column, press [EDIT]+[UP or DOWN] to launch the **Effects Command Help view** (manual p.48).
- Filter cutoff is a Macrosynth-specific parameter. The FX command to set the Macrosynth filter cutoff is found in **Instrument FX Commands** (manual p.75) — look for the Macrosynth filter command (browse the Effect Command Help view in-device).
- Build a 4-step stepped filter sweep using whichever command the help view shows for Macrosynth filter cutoff. Example pattern (values are illustrative, use the actual command code shown):
 - Row 00: cutoff = 20
 - Row 01: cutoff = 50
 - Row 02: cutoff = 80
 - Row 03: cutoff = 50
- Set TABLE TIC in Instrument View to control table speed. Default 01 = 1 tick per step.
- Compare: the slot LFO is smooth and continuous, the table is stepped and locked to your tic rate. **Use whichever fits the sound.**

Tip

- Use [M8 table editor](#) in your browser to experiment with table layouts before entering them on the device.

Thread 2: Synthesis fundamental — Envelopes (ADSR)

Goal: understand that envelope shape defines instrument identity more than oscillator does.

The Instrument Modulation View also handles envelopes. The same modulation slots that can be LFOs can also be AHD, ADSR, DRUM, TRIG, or TRACKING envelopes (manual p.18–21).

- Open a fresh Wavsynth or Macrosynth instrument.
- In Instrument Modulation View, set MOD1 to ADSR ENVELOPE, DEST to VOLUME (or AMP).
- Configure ADSR (manual p.20):
 - ATK (attack): time to reach AMT
 - DEC (decay): time to reach sustain

- SUS (sustain): hold level while note plays
- REL (release): time to fall to zero after note ends
- **Pluck**: ATK=00, DEC=20, SUS=00, REL=10. Hear: percussive, snappy.
- **Pad**: ATK=60, DEC=00, SUS=7F, REL=80. Same oscillator, completely different instrument.
- Realize: attack and release are doing 80% of the work in defining what something *sounds like*.

Guitar parallel

How a note attacks (pick vs. tap vs. volume-knob swell) and decays (palm mute vs. full sustain) defines tone more than which guitar is plugged in. Same principle.

Thread 3: Arrangement principle — A/B contrast

Goal: make Project 1 have two clearly different sections.

- Add a **B section** to Project 1. Build a new chain (Song View: navigate to empty column, [EDIT] then [EDIT]+[EDIT] to create new empty chain).
 - B differs from A in **exactly one specific way**. Not "different everything."
 - Pick one:
 - Drums drop out for the B section
 - One new melodic element enters that's absent from A
 - Filter on bass opens fully (LFO depth or chain transpose change)
 - Key transposes (use TSP column in Chain View — transposes in semitones)
 - Commit to one. If you find yourself adding a second change, undo it.
-

■ Deliverable

- Project 1 now has A and B sections in Song View.
- Bass instrument has either a modulation-slot LFO or a table-based filter sweep — your choice.
- At least one instrument has a deliberate ADSR shape (not default).
- ~60 second loop minimum.
- Render to WAV (Render View, manual p.47).

Week 3 — Pitch slides, velocity, and Tracking

Goal: Two more techniques in your toolbox: pitch slides via the PIT command (real, documented), and velocity-driven modulation via the **Tracking** modulation type.

Manual references: Scale View (mentions PIT, p.28), Tracking modulation type (p.21), Sequencer FX Commands (p.69), Instrument FX Commands (p.75), Effect Command Help View (p.48).

Thread 1: M8 technique — Pitch slides and velocity response

Pitch slides via PIT

The PIT command is a real M8 effect command (confirmed in Scale view section, manual p.28). It works as a pitch effect that can be quantized to the current scale.

- Open the bass instrument in Project 1.
- In Phrase View, position cursor on an FX column next to a bass note. Press [EDIT]+[UP or DOWN] to open the **Effect Command Help view** (manual p.48).
- Find PIT in the command list. The help view shows the parameter range and behavior.
- Build an acid-style bassline by alternating notes and PIT slides:
 - Row 00: C-2, FX1: PIT with positive value (slide up)
 - Row 04: C-2, FX1: PIT with negative value (slide down)
- Experiment with PIT values. Use the in-device help text at the bottom of the screen — it shows the decimal equivalent and what the value does.
- **Scale-aware:** if you have a SCA (scale) command active on the track, PIT slides quantize to the scale (manual p.28). Useful for keeping slides in key.

Velocity-driven modulation via Tracking

This is where the M8 gets clever about humanization. Instead of manually setting volumes per step, you assign **Tracking** modulation that maps note velocity to any parameter.

- Open the hi-hat instrument (Sampler with a hat sample, or Wavsynth with noise + short envelope).
- Go to Instrument Modulation View ([SHIFT]+[UP] from Instrument View).
- Configure an unused MOD slot:
 - TYPE: TRACKING
 - SRC: VELOCITY (or VELOCITY TAKEOVER to disable velocity affecting volume directly)
 - DEST: pick a parameter — try VOLUME, FILTER CUTOFF, or PITCH for variety
 - LVAL: lowest source value (e.g. 00)
 - HVAL: highest source value (e.g. 7F)

- Reference: Tracking modulation, manual p.21.
- Back in Phrase View, vary the v column on hi-hat hits: some at 64 (default), some at 20, some at 7F. The Tracking modulation now translates velocity into your chosen parameter changes.
- **Ghost notes for snare:** same approach. Set Tracking on snare → velocity → volume. Then put low-velocity hits (e.g. v=10) between the main hits.

Why this matters

Velocity ramping via tables (manual command in v column or table) works, but **Tracking is more flexible**: same velocity column can drive multiple parameters at once if you set up multiple MOD slots. This is how M8 patches feel alive without writing a million variations.

Thread 2: Synthesis fundamental — Filters

Goal: hear what filter cutoff and resonance actually do.

- Open a Macrosynth bass instrument. Make sure FILTER section is active.
- Set RES (resonance) to a low value (~20).
- Manually sweep CUTOFF from 00 to FF while a note plays. Listen: muffled → bright → bright with the high harmonics audible.
- Now increase RES to ~A0. Sweep CUTOFF again. Hear the "vocal," whistling quality at the cutoff point. That's resonance.
- Macrosynth filter modes — check the Macrosynth reference (manual p.52) for the available filter types and how to switch between LP/HP/BP if available on the model.

Guitar parallel

Cutoff is where the wah pedal points; resonance is how "vocal" the wah sounds. The lowpass filter is your tone knob.

Thread 3: Arrangement principle — Add/remove with intent

Goal: every element change should have a reason.

- In Project 1: add ONE new element to the B section.
- Before adding, answer: **what does this make space for, or what does it replace?**
- Then remove ONE element from late A.
- Before removing, answer: **what now has room to breathe?**
- If either answer is "nothing" or "I don't know," the change is wrong. Undo and try a different one.
- This is the discipline: every arrangement decision is a tradeoff.

■ Deliverable

- Project 1 has intentional element changes between A and B.
- Bass uses PIT for at least one slide.

- Hats or snare have a Tracking modulation responding to velocity.
 - ~90 second loop.
 - Render to WAV (Render View, manual p.47).
-

■ ■ Mix focus this week: kick & bass relationship

The most important relationship in any electronic mix. Get this right and 50% of mixing is done.

Reference: Mixing Reference → Scope A, Steps 1–2.

- Solo kick. Set its volume to peak around -6dBFS in Mixer View.
- Unmute bass. Listen with kick. Can you hear both distinctly?
- If they fight, do one of these (in order):
 - **Easiest:** lower bass volume
 - **Better:** LOWCUT on bass below 40Hz (Instrument EQ, p.32). Removes subsonic conflict.
 - **Best:** TRIG envelope side-chain on bass, ducked by kick. See Mixing Reference → Tool 3 for full setup.
- Verify on headphones AND M8 speakers. Both elements audible on both systems = win.

Week 4 — Retriggers, arpeggios, LFO concept

Goal: Third table-class technique. Project 1 reaches its ~2 minute draft state, but **doesn't finish this week** — finishing happens in Weeks 5–6 with proper mix and finalization.

This is the last pure-technique week before Phase 2 (Apply).

The RET command appears widely in M8 community discussions, but the manual's full FX command appendix is large — verify it in your device's **Effect Command Help view** before using. The ARP command IS documented in the manual (p.8, p.28). Use the in-device help as the source of truth.

Manual references: Effect Command Help View (p.48), Sequencer FX Commands (p.69), Instrument FX Commands (p.75), Common Groove Examples (p.81).

Thread 1: M8 technique — Retriggers and arpeggios

Verify before using

- On any FX column in Phrase or Table View, press [EDIT]+[UP or DOWN] to open the **Effect Command Help view** (manual p.48).
- Browse the available commands. The view shows real-time which commands are valid for the current instrument type.
- Confirm ARP (arpeggio — definitely real, see p.8 example "ARP37").
- Confirm whether a retrigger command exists for your instrument (look for RET, RTG, or similar in the help view).

Arpeggios

ARP37 = arpeggio with first interval +3 semitones, second +7 semitones. Two digits = two intervals (manual p.8).

- On a melodic instrument in Project 1, add ARP to a chord-stab note.
- Try ARP37 (major triad), ARP47 (minor third + perfect fifth = sus arpeggio variant), ARP35 (minor triad).
- ARP respects the scale set via SCA command (manual p.28) — useful for keeping arpeggios in key.

Retriggers / rolls

- Find the retrigger command via the help view. It's used for snare rolls, glitched hat patterns, the staccato tracker feel.
- Add a retrigger to a snare hit somewhere in Project 1 (test a snare roll fill).
- Try it on a hi-hat for stuttery effect.

Probability and fills (generative variation)

See *Generative Toolkit Reference* → #1 and #3 for the full toolkit context.

The M8 has built-in randomization in Phrase View selection mode (manual p.15). This is your generative tool for late-stage humanization — patterns that feel alive without writing variations.

Recipe — humanize a hi-hat pattern that feels rigid:

- In Phrase View, position cursor over the hi-hat notes you want to vary.
- Enter selection mode: [SHIFT]+[OPTION].
- **Important: note column must be selected** (not velocity or instrument column). The fill modes only work on note column.
- Try each of these in order:
 - [OPTION]+[UP or DOWN] — randomizes note values up/down (subtle pitch variation)
 - [OPTION]+[LEFT] — cycles through note fill modes
 - [OPTION]+[RIGHT] — randomizes note AND instrument triggers
- Exit selection mode. The result is committed.
- **If you don't like the result:** paste immediately ([SHIFT]+[EDIT]) to undo the fill action. This is per-manual: "When exiting selection mode after a fill action, perform a paste to undo."

Common failure mode: Trying these key combos on the velocity, instrument, or FX columns. They only work on the note column. Other columns just navigate normally.

Try this on Project 1:

- Find one rigid-feeling pattern in Project 1. Hi-hats are the usual culprit.
- Apply randomization. Render and listen.
- Keep if better, undo if worse. No commitment.

Thread 2: Synthesis fundamental — LFOs as a concept

Goal: realize the LFO from Week 2 and the table-based modulation from Week 2 are the same family.

An LFO is anything that:

- Oscillates slowly
- Modulates a destination

Three properties: **rate** (FREQ), **depth** (AMT), **destination** (DEST).

- Take a Wavsynth instrument. In Instrument Modulation View, set up two LFO slots simultaneously:
 - MOD1: LFO → PITCH, slow rate, low amount = subtle vibrato
 - MOD2: LFO → VOLUME, faster rate, medium amount = tremolo
- Same LFO concept, different destinations = totally different effects.
- Now you understand: the table from Week 2's "Method B" was just a *manual, stepped LFO*. Same family.

Thread 3: Arrangement principle — Designed transitions

Goal: A→B should have a moment of motion, not just a cut.

- Add **one designed transition** between A and B in Project 1. Pick one:
 - **Snare roll** — use the retrigger command from Thread 1
 - **Filter sweep** — automate DJ filter (DJF) in Mixer View, or use a table on a noise sweep instrument
 - **Pitch downsweep** on a bass note — use PIT over consecutive table rows
 - **Beat repeat / stutter** via retriggers
 - **Silence** — one bar of nothing right before B drops
 - Commit to **one**. Don't stack five.
-

■ Deliverable — PROJECT 1 DRAFT COMPLETE

- Project 1 is now a ~2 minute track with A section, B section, designed transition, dynamic elements.
- Render a rough WAV for reference (no mix or master pass yet).
- **Save and walk away.** Don't try to mix or polish — that's Weeks 5–6.
- Notice: this is the first time you've gotten a track to "draft complete" on M8 in this cycle. The hard part starts next week (mixing), but the writing is done.

Week 5 — Mix Project 1

Goal: Take Project 1 from "draft complete" (Week 4) to "mixed and clear." **No new technique this week. No finalization yet.** Pure mixing focus.

This is the start of Phase 2 (Apply). The writing is done. Now you learn to make it sound right.

Reference (read first): Mixing Reference — full Scope A workflow.

Time-box: 60 min max per session, 2–3 sessions this week. **Do not exceed.** Mixing rewards stopping, not over-tweaking.

Session 1 (~60 min) — Foundation: kick & bass

The most important relationship in the mix. Get this right and 50% of mixing is done.

Reference: Mixing Reference → Scope A, Steps 1–2.

- Open Project 1 on M8.
- Mute everything except kick ([OPTION]+[SHIFT] per track in Song View).
- In Mixer View, set kick volume to peak around -6 dBFS.
- EQ kick if needed: boost 60–80Hz (body), cut 200–400Hz (mud), optional boost 3–5kHz (click). Per-instrument EQ via Instrument View → EQ slot → [SHIFT]+[RIGHT].
- Unmute bass. Listen with kick.
- Set bass volume so kick still cuts through.
- If they fight, in order of escalation:

Lower bass volume

- **LOWCUT bass** below 40Hz (removes sub conflict)
 - **Notch bass** at kick's fundamental (60–80Hz)
 - **TRIG envelope side-chain** — bass ducks when kick triggers. See Mixing Reference → Tool 3 for the full setup (TYPE: TRIG ENVELOPE, SRC: kick instrument number, DEST: VOLUME, AMT: negative).
 - Verify on **two systems**: M8 speakers AND headphones (or phone speakers). Both kick AND bass audible distinctly on both.
 - **Stop at 60 min.** If kick and bass aren't working after an hour, the kick or bass instrument itself is wrong — note it for Week 7 (library week), don't fix it now.
-

Session 2 (~60 min) — Drums as a kit + melodic balance

Reference: Mixing Reference → Scope A, Steps 3–4.

Step 1: Drums coherent (25 min)

- Unmute snare and hats. Balance against kick + bass.

- EQ separation:
 - Snare: BELL boost ~200Hz (body), BELL boost ~5kHz (snap)
 - Hi-hats: LOWCUT ~300Hz, HI.SHELF boost above 8kHz
- Listen as a group. Drums should feel like one kit, not three separate elements.

Step 2: Melodic elements (25 min)

- Unmute melodic tracks one at a time.
- EQ: LOWCUT melodic elements below 100–200Hz. Keeps low end clean for kick/bass.
- Add reverb/delay sends for depth on a few elements. **Less than you think.**
- Lead/main element = dry-leaning, central. Pads/atmosphere = wetter, wider.

Step 3: Quick check (10 min)

- Full mix unmuted. Listen all the way through Project 1.
 - One pass only. Note 1–2 issues if any. **Don't fix them this session.**
-

Session 3 (~60 min, optional) — Polish and verify

Only do this session if Session 2 left you with clear, specific issues.

- Address 1–2 specific issues from Session 2. **Maximum two fixes.**
 - Listen on a third system if available (laptop, car, somewhere new).
 - **Final check question:** "Is anything obviously wrong on 2+ systems?" If no, you're done. If yes, do exactly one more fix and then stop.
-

■ Deliverable

- Project 1 is mixed. All elements balanced, audible, not fighting.
 - Render a reference WAV (no master yet, just rendered mix).
 - Listen to it once on a system you haven't used during mixing. Note your gut reaction.
 - **Save mix state.** Next week is finalization, not more mixing.
-

Mixing anti-patterns to watch for

- **Soloing for more than 30 seconds.** Mix happens in context, not in solo.
- **Looping one bar.** Sounds great in a loop, falls apart in a full track.
- **EQ'ing instead of fixing the instrument.** If something needs more than 6dB of EQ to work, the instrument is wrong.
- **Adding reverb to fix balance issues.** Reverb doesn't fix mix problems, it adds new ones.
- **Mixing late at night.** Ears get tired and you over-compensate. Mix when fresh.

Week 6 — Finalize and ship Project 1

Goal: Take the mixed Project 1 (Week 5 output) through finalization and ship it. **First release-ready track shipped in this cycle.**

No new technique. No new mixing. Just finalize, render, share.

Reference (read first): Finalization Reference — Scope A workflow.

Time-box: 60 min for finalization, 30 min for verification, total ~90 min over 1–2 sessions.

Session 1 (~60 min) — Finalization pass

Follow the Scope A workflow from the Finalization Reference exactly.

Step 1: Pre-master mix check (10 min)

This is a *verification*, not a real mix. You did the real mix last week.

- Play Project 1 from Song View, start to finish.
- In Mixer View, watch the meters for red bars (clipping).
- If you notice major balance issues, **stop and go back to Week 5 mixing**. Don't fix mix problems at the master stage.
- If the mix is solid, proceed.

Step 2: Main mix EQ (10 min)

- Mixer View → EQ → [SHIFT]+[RIGHT] to enter EQ Editor.
- **High-pass the mix:** LOW band TYPE=LOWCUT, FREQ~30Hz.
- Optional gentle moves on MID/HIGH bands. **Max 3dB.**

Step 3: OTT compression (5 min)

- Mixer View → OTT parameter.
- Bring up slowly. Target 20–40. Above 60 it gets crushed.
- If it makes the track worse, leave at 00.

Step 4: Limiter (10 min)

- Mixer View → LIM → [SHIFT]+[RIGHT] to Limiter & Mix Scope View.
- Start LIM at 40, push up while watching the compression line.
- Target: 2–4dB compression on peaks. **6dB+ = squashing.**
- ATK: 20–40. REL: 00 (AUTO).
- SOFT CLIP: gentle. Adds warmth.

Step 5: Render (5 min)

- Project View → Render.

- 44.1kHz, 16-bit WAV (or 24-bit if planning Week 10 Scope B).
- Save with clear filename: Project1_master_v1.wav or similar.

Step 6: First listen (20 min, fresh)

- Listen to the rendered WAV once, end to end. **No fixing yet.**
 - Note 1–2 things you'd want to verify on other systems.
 - **Don't open the project again today.**
-

Session 2 (~30 min) — Multi-system verification + ship

Step 1: Three-system listening test (15 min)

Listen to Project1_master_v1.wav on three systems:

- **Phone speakers** — worst case. Bass audible? Leads clear? Anything painful?
- **Headphones** — stereo image, depth, detail.
- **Laptop speakers** or car — overall balance.

For each: 1–2 short notes.

Step 2: One allowed fix (10 min, only if needed)

Are there problems on **2+ systems consistently**?

- If no: master is done. Skip to Step 3.
- If yes, one consistent issue: **one allowed fix**. Adjust master, re-render. **Done.**
- If yes, multiple consistent issues: the mix has problems. Note them for next time. **Ship as-is anyway.**

Step 3: Ship it (5 min)

- Rename final WAV: Project1_FINAL.wav (or your naming).
 - Put it somewhere you won't lose it.
 - Send it to **one person outside your own ears**. Discord, friend, partner. Sharing is part of finishing.
 - Optional: post to Bandcamp/Soundcloud as a private/unlisted track. Doesn't have to be public release — just out of your hands.
-

■ Deliverable — PROJECT 1 SHIPPED

- First M8 track finished in this cycle. Properly mixed, finalized, shipped.
 - WAV exists. One other person has heard it.
 - Notice what you just did. The gear hasn't been the blocker, this whole time. The structure was.
-

After Week 6

- Week 7 is the library week — no track, just instruments. Use it as recovery.
 - **Don't immediately start thinking about Project 2.** Phase 2 ended successfully. Sit with that for a moment.
-

Anti-perfectionism rules

- **Master once, walk away.** No second passes after the one allowed fix.
- **Don't compare Project 1 to professional tracks.** They had years and proper monitoring.
- **The bad first masters are the point.** This is master #1 of many. Quality compounds with quantity.
- **Shipping > polishing.** A shipped imperfect track teaches more than a perfect unfinished one.

Week 7 — Starter instrument library

Goal: Build 10 personal instruments you'll reuse forever. **No track this week.** Pure library-building.

This is the recovery week between Project 1 (shipped Week 6) and Project 2 (built Week 8). Use it for instrument design without performance pressure.

Manual references: Instrument View (p.16), Instrument Modulation View (p.18), Wavsynth (p.50), Macrosynth (p.52), Sampler (p.54), FM Synth (p.58), Hypersynth (p.60).

Strategy: before designing from scratch, reverse-engineer 1–2 existing instruments. Open the Community Starter Pack or laamaa's instruments and inspect how their parameters and modulation slots are set up. Then design your own.

Thread 1: M8 technique — Build the 10 instruments

Setup

- Decide a naming convention. Suggested: EG-Bass-Sub, EG-Bass-Acid, EG-Lead-Pluck. M8 NAME field is limited length — keep short.
- Save each via Instrument View → SAVE. They save to /Instruments/ on the SD card.

Bass instruments

- **Sub bass** — EG-Bass-Sub
 - TYPE: wavsynth (sine) or Macrosynth (clean sine model)
 - MOD1: ADSR → VOLUME, ATK=00, DEC=20, SUS=60, REL=20
 - **Instrument EQ:** LOWCUT below 40Hz (pre-mixed for kick compatibility)
- **Acid bass** — EG-Bass-Acid
 - TYPE: Macrosynth, model with strong filter (Macrosynth Models, p.76)
 - FILTER CUTOFF mid (~50), RES high (~B0)
 - MOD1: LFO → FILTER CUTOFF, OSC=TRI, FREQ=08, AMT=40
 - Table: a few PIT slides built in
 - **Instrument EQ:** LOWCUT below 40Hz
- **FM bass** — EG-Bass-FM
 - TYPE: FM Synth (manual p.58)
 - Browse factory FM presets first. Modify for grit.
 - Add filter movement via MOD slot.
 - **Instrument EQ:** LOWCUT below 40Hz

Lead/melodic instruments

- **Pluck lead** — EG-Lead-Pluck

- TYPE: Macrosynth or Wavsynth, sawtooth
- MOD1: ADSR → VOLUME, ATK=00, DEC=10, SUS=00, REL=08 (very short)
- MOD2: ADSR → FILTER CUTOFF, ATK=00, DEC=30, SUS=00, REL=00, AMT=60
- **Instrument EQ:** LOWCUT below 100–200Hz

■ Pad — EG-Pad

- TYPE: Macrosynth, soft model
- MOD1: ADSR → VOLUME, ATK=60, DEC=00, SUS=7F, REL=A0
- MOD2: LFO → FILTER CUTOFF, OSC=SIN, FREQ=20, AMT=20
- **Instrument EQ:** LOWCUT below 200Hz, cut 200–500Hz to avoid mud

■ Stab/chord — EG-Stab

- TYPE: Macrosynth or Hypersynth (p.60) for built-in chords
- Short attack, short decay, no sustain
- **Instrument EQ:** LOWCUT below 150Hz

Drum instruments

■ Kick — EG-Drum-Kick

- TYPE: Sampler with kick sample, OR FM Synth for FM kick
- If FM: ADSR on pitch (high→low, fast) + ADSR on volume (short)
- **Instrument EQ:** boost 60–80Hz, cut 200–400Hz

■ Snare — EG-Drum-Snare

- TYPE: Sampler with snare, OR Wavsynth noise layered with tonal
- Tracking modulation: VELOCITY → VOLUME for natural feel
- **Instrument EQ:** BELL boost ~200Hz, BELL boost ~5kHz

■ Closed hat — EG-Drum-Hat-C

- TYPE: Wavsynth (noise) or Sampler
- ATK=00, DEC=04, SUS=00, REL=02
- Tracking modulation: VELOCITY → VOLUME
- **Instrument EQ:** LOWCUT 300Hz, HI.SHELF boost above 8kHz

■ Open hat — EG-Drum-Hat-O

- Same as closed but DEC=20, REL=10
- **Instrument EQ:** same as closed hat

Bonus

■ Noise sweep — EG-FX-Sweep

- TYPE: Wavsynth, noise
- Long table or modulation slot automating filter cutoff closed → open

- For transitions. Trigger once at end of A section.

Cross-check by reverse-engineering

- Load the [Community Starter Pack](#) onto your SD card.
- Open a few instruments. See modulation slot setups. Borrow what you like.
- Open [laamaa's instruments](#) too.

Thread 2: Synthesis fundamental — FM basics

Goal: stop being afraid of the FM Synth.

- Open FM Synth instrument type (manual p.58). 4-op FM.
- Concept: one operator's frequency modulates another's. The modulator's frequency RATIO to the carrier defines timbre.
- Integer ratios (1:1, 1:2, 2:1) = harmonic, musical.
- Non-integer ratios (1:1.41) = clanky, bell-like, metallic.
- Play with operator ratios. Don't aim for mastery — just lose the fear.

Thread 3: Generative exploration

Library week is the right time for low-stakes feature exploration. No track pressure means you can play with things that didn't click before.

See Generative Toolkit Reference → #4 and #5 for full context. Pick one or more — not required to complete the library week.

Option A: Table TIC modes (velocity- or note-mapped instruments)

This is what tables look like when they stop being step sequencers and become input-responsive instruments. Manual p.24, Table TIC Modes.

Recipe — velocity-mapped drum hit:

- Pick one of your starter drum instruments (kick or snare).
- In Instrument View, set TABLE TIC to TICFD (velocity map).
- Enter the instrument's table. Each row now corresponds to a velocity range.
- Row 00: leave default (lowest velocity hits)
- Row 04: add PIT with small positive value (medium velocity = slight up-pitch)
- Row 08: more PIT + slight volume boost
- Row 0C: significant PIT + add reverb send via FX command
- Now varying velocity on this drum produces real variations, not just volume changes.
- **Save as a new instrument** (e.g. EG-Drum-Snare-V for velocity-responsive version).

Common failure mode: forgetting to change TABLE TIC. Without setting it to TICFD/TICFE/TICFC, the table just plays linearly and none of the input mapping happens.

Option B: Hypersynth (chord generation)

Manual p.60. Hypersynth is a different model from the synths you've used — it generates chords from single notes rather than producing one tone.

- Open an empty instrument slot. Set TYPE to Hypersynth.
- Spend 15–20 min exploring its parameters in Instrument View. Don't aim for a finished sound — just understand what each parameter does.
- Hypersynth respects the project's Scale (p.28). Set a scale on the track via SCA FX command, or globally via SCG.
- Play a single note in Phrase View. Hypersynth generates the chord around it.
- Try different scale settings. Hear how the same note produces different chords depending on the scale.
- **If you like it:** save as EG-Hyper-Chord or similar, add to library.
- **If not:** no worries, you've at least lost the fear of opening it.

Common failure mode: treating Hypersynth like Wavsynth (picking a wave shape). It's a chord-generation model — you're configuring how chords are built, not what waves they're made of. If a Hypersynth note sounds like a single tone, the chord parameters need tweaking.

Option C: Sliced drum kit (one Sampler, multiple sounds)

The "drum rack" approach that Week 1 deliberately avoided. Worth exploring now that you have separate drum instruments working.

Recipe — chromatic slice playback:

- Find or make a multi-hit drum chain .wav (one file with kick, snare, hat, etc. concatenated). [DigiChain](#) is a browser tool that builds these and writes M8-compatible slice markers.
- Open an empty instrument slot. TYPE: Sampler. SAMPLE: load the drum chain .wav.
- **Slice the sample.** In Instrument View, navigate to the sample's slice settings. Two slicing modes you'll typically use (manual p.54):
 - AUTO — auto-slice on transients. Best when drum hits have clear attack peaks (most drum kits).
 - SILENCE — auto-slice on silence gaps. Best when hits are separated by clear silence (one-shot recordings with padding).
 - (EVEN mode also exists for evenly-spaced slicing up to 128 slices, but for variable-length drum chains AUTO or SILENCE give better results.)
- **Trigger slices chromatically by note.** Set the SLICE parameter in Instrument View so each note maps to a different slice. In Phrase View, different notes (e.g. C-4, C#4, D-4) on this instrument now trigger slice 1, slice 2, slice 3, etc.
- Build a drum pattern using note variation instead of instrument-number variation — like playing a drum rack.

When to use this vs separate Samplers (Week 1 approach):

- Separate Samplers (Week 1) — simpler, more flexible per-sound, what most M8 users do.

- Sliced kit (this option) — saves instrument slots when you need many sounds and only have a few free slots. Also great for chopped breakbeats and vocal phrase manipulation.

Common failure mode: loading a sliced chain into a Sampler with SLICE 000FF (default) and expecting it to behave like a drum kit. With SLICE 000FF, the instrument just plays the whole file and transposes by note. You need slice markers (via AUTO or SILENCE) AND a non-zero SLICE parameter so notes map to slices.

Mix focus this week: instruments are pre-mixed

Every instrument above has an instrument EQ pre-configured. This prevents 90% of future mix problems and means Week 8 builds tracks that mix faster.

Reference: Mixing Reference → Frequency carving recipes.

■ Deliverable

- 10 instruments saved to /Instruments/EG-* on SD card with consistent naming.
- Each has its instrument EQ pre-configured per its role.
- Render a 30-second demo cycling through each instrument (16 bars each, all 10 instruments in sequence). This is your reference for Week 8.
- No track this week.

Week 8 — Build Project 2

Goal: Fresh project. Own instruments. All accumulated techniques. ~3 minute track at draft state by end of week.

No mixing or finalization this week. Those are Week 9. This week is pure building.

This is the week the "meander" problem gets fixed.

Manual references: Song View (p.10), Chain View (p.12), Phrase View (p.14), Time Stats View (p.46).

Thread 1: M8 technique — Apply everything

Setup (Session 1, 60 min)

- In Project View, create a new project. Name it Project2.
- In Instrument Pool View, load 4–6 of your EG- * instruments from Week 7. **No factory presets.** This is the test.
- Don't choose all 10 — constraint forces creativity.
- Set tempo in Project View. Pick and commit.
- Build a 4-bar A section: drums + bass + 1–2 melodic elements.

Build out (Sessions 2–3, 60 min each)

- Build a B section with intentional contrast (one specific change, not five).
- Chain A and B into a song structure in Song View.
- **Apply at least one of each accumulated technique:**
 - LFO via modulation slot OR table-based stepped automation (Week 2)
 - PIT slide somewhere (Week 3)
 - Tracking modulation on at least one drum (Week 3)
 - ARP or retrigger somewhere (Week 4)
 - A designed transition between sections (Week 4)
- **Optional generative shortcut for melody:** if you're stuck writing melodic content, try tables as arpeggiators. See Generative Toolkit Reference → #6.
 - On a melodic instrument, set TABLE TIC to a fast value (02 or 04).
 - In the table's N column, write a sequence: 00, 04, 07, 0C, 07, 04 (major arp up and down).
 - Trigger ONE note in Phrase View. The table plays the arp.
 - Faster than writing every note. Great when you want movement but lack inspiration.
- Don't force all of them. Use what fits.
- Aim for ~3 minutes total. Use Time Stats View (p.46) to monitor.

Structure target

- Rough shape: intro → A → B → A' → B' → outro. Gentle development style applies.
- Not pop verse/chorus. A+B style with drops/risers is the goal.

Thread 2: Synthesis fundamental — Effects as sound design

Goal: realize effects aren't polish, they're instrument character.

The M8 has 3 send effects: ModFX (chorus/phaser/flanger), Delay, Reverb (manual p.36–37).

- Take one of your EG- * instruments. Set its REV send high (~80).
- In Effect Settings View ([SHIFT]+[DOWN] from Mixer View), set Reverb SIZE high, DECAY long.
- Hear: ambient, distant, atmospheric. Different instrument.
- Take another. Set its DEL send. Delay TIME = 40 (4 beats), FEEDBACK ~60.
- Hear: rhythmic doubling, more space.
- In Project 2: at least **one element wet and one element dry**. Contrast.

Thread 3: Arrangement — THE ARRIVAL

This is the week the meander problem gets fixed.

Decide before you start

- **Before writing any notes** in Project 2: decide where the arrival point is. Most likely around 1:45–2:15 of a 3-minute track.
- Decide WHAT happens at the arrival. Pick one:
 - The full beat finally drops (kick + everything in)
 - A melodic element finally enters
 - Everything drops out except one element (negative arrival)
 - Filter fully opens on a sound that's been muted/restricted
 - A new key/transpose hits via Chain View TSP
- Write toward that moment from minute 0.

Self-check during the week

Every section asks one of two questions:

- **Before the arrival:** *Am I building toward it?* Increasing tension, adding elements, raising filter, building energy.
- **After the arrival:** *Am I releasing the energy that built?* Releasing tension, removing elements, lowering filter, dissipating.

If a section answers "no" to both, that section is the problem. Cut it or rebuild it.

■ Deliverable — PROJECT 2 DRAFT COMPLETE

- Project 2 is ~3 minutes long.
- Uses only your EG- * instruments.
- Has a clear arrival point at a specific timestamp.
- Render a rough WAV (draft, no mix or master pass yet).
- **Save and walk away.** Week 9 is mixing + finalizing.
- Notice: you built a track using your own instruments and your own techniques. The whole pipeline.

Week 9 — Finalize and ship Project 2

Goal: Take Project 2 from draft (Week 8) to mixed, finalized, shipped. Second release-ready M8 track in this cycle.

Combines mix + finalization in one week (vs Project 1 which had separate weeks). You have the skills now — this is application speed, not learning speed.

References:

- Mixing Reference for Scope A mix
- Finalization Reference for Scope A master

Time-box: 3 sessions, 60 min each.

Session 1 (~60 min) — Scope A mix pass

Follow the full Mixing Reference Scope A workflow:

- Step 1: Solo kick, set baseline volume
- Step 2: Add bass, balance against kick (side-chain if needed)
- Step 3: Add drums as a kit
- Step 4: Add melodic elements with appropriate depth (reverb/delay sends)
- Step 5: Full mix listen on 2 systems
- **Hard time limit: 60 min.** Mix is done when nothing obvious is wrong on 2 systems.

Note

Project 2 should mix faster than Project 1 because your EG-* instruments are pre-EQ'd from Week 7. If you're spending more than 60 min, the issue is likely in the instruments or the arrangement, not the mix.

Session 2 (~60 min) — Scope A finalization

Follow the Finalization Reference Scope A workflow:

- Pre-master mix verification (10 min)
- Main mix EQ — high-pass at 30Hz, gentle tone shaping (10 min)
- OTT compression (5 min)
- Limiter — 2–4dB compression on peaks (10 min)
- Render to WAV (5 min)
- First listen, fresh ears (20 min)

Save as Project2_master_v1.wav.

Session 3 (~60 min) — Multi-system check + ship

Step 1: Three-system listening test (20 min)

- Phone speakers
- Headphones
- Laptop speakers or car

1–2 notes per system.

Step 2: One allowed fix (15 min, only if needed)

Problems on 2+ systems consistently?

- If no: done. Skip to Step 3.
- If yes, one issue: one fix allowed. Re-render.
- If yes, multiple issues: ship as-is. Note for next cycle.

Step 3: Ship it (25 min)

- Rename: `Project2_FINAL.wav`.
 - Send to at least one person outside your ears.
 - Optional: post somewhere (Bandcamp unlisted, Soundcloud private, Discord) — doesn't need to be public.
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■ Deliverable — PROJECT 2 SHIPPED

- Second M8 track finished and shipped in this cycle.
 - Track uses your own instruments, your own techniques, your own arrangement vocabulary.
 - One other person has heard it.
-

After Week 9

- **Take a deliberate week off.** No M8. No other gear. No browsing.
 - Optional: do Week 10 (Scope B Ableton mix + master) on Project 2 if you want a release-ready, streaming-loudness version.
 - Then reflect: write notes on what worked, what didn't, what to carry into the next learning cycle.
-

Anti-perfectionism rules

- **Two passes max total** (master + one allowed fix).
- **No comparing Project 2 to Project 1.** They're not the same kind of work.
- **The improvement from Project 1 to Project 2 is the win**, not absolute quality.
- **Ship even if you don't love it.** Two shipped tracks in ~9 weeks is a real achievement. Quality compounds with quantity.

Week 10 — Scope B mix + master in Ableton (optional)

This week is optional. Skip if Project 2's Scope A version (Week 9) is good enough, or if you're burnt out, or if you don't care about streaming loudness.

Goal: Take Project 2's stems through a Scope B pass in Ableton. End with a release-ready file you'd publish to Bandcamp/Soundcloud/Spotify.

Time commitment: 3 sessions, 60 min each. **Hard limits.**

References:

- Mixing Reference → Scope B workflow
 - Finalization Reference → Scope B mastering chain
-

Session 1 (~60 min) — Render stems + Ableton mix

Step 1: Render stems from M8 (15 min)

Reference: Mixing Reference → Scope B → Stem rendering.

- Open Project 2 on M8.
- Render each of the 8 tracks individually:
 - Mute all tracks except track 1. Render. Save as Project2_T1.wav.
 - Mute all except track 2. Render. Save as Project2_T2.wav.
 - Repeat through track 8.
- Keep per-instrument EQ and effects on M8 — render the M8 sound, not raw oscillators.
- You should now have up to 8 stem WAV files.

Step 2: Scope B mix in Ableton (40 min)

Reference: Mixing Reference → Scope B → Minimal Ableton mix.

- New Ableton project. Import all stems on separate audio tracks.
- Pull all faders down. Start from silence.
- Follow mix order: kick → bass → drums → melodic → effects.
- Apply EQ on each stem (same Scope A principles, but with surgical Ableton EQ).
- Optional: bus compression on drum group, side-chain via Ableton's sidechain compressor.
- Reference against one professional track.
- **Hard limit: 40 min.**

Step 3: Render mix (5 min)

- Render the mixed track (no master chain yet) to WAV. 44.1kHz, 24-bit.

- Save as `Project2_mixed.wav`. **Don't apply master in this session.**
-

Session 2 (~60 min) — Mix triage + master

Step 1: Listen fresh (10 min)

- Listen to `Project2_mixed.wav` once, no notes during.
- Write 1–3 specific issues after.

Step 2: Decide — triage or master as-is? (5 min)

- 0–1 issues: master as-is.
- 2–3 obvious issues: triage in Ableton (Step 3).
- 4+ issues: pick 2 worst or accept and master as-is. **Don't rebuild.**

Step 3: Mix triage in Ableton (15 min, if needed)

- Fix 1–2 issues only. Levels, EQ, sends.
- **Do not touch arrangement.**
- Re-render as `Project2_mixed_v2.wav`.

Step 4: Scope B mastering pass (30 min, hard limit)

Reference: Finalization Reference → Scope B chain.

- New Ableton project (or new chain). Import mixed render.
- Import reference track.
- Apply: HP filter → bus EQ → Glue Compressor → Limiter.
- Target ≈ 14 LUFS (or genre-appropriate).
- A/B against reference. Close the gap, don't match perfectly.
- **Stop at 30 min.** Set a timer.

Save as `Project2_master_v2.wav`.

Session 3 (~60 min) — Multi-system check + acceptance

Step 1: Three-system test (30 min)

Listen on:

- Phone speakers
- Headphones
- Laptop or car

1–2 notes per system.

Step 2: Decision (10 min)

- No cross-system issues: done. Step 4.

- One consistent issue: one allowed fix. Step 3.
- Multiple consistent issues: accept as-is, note for next time.

Step 3: One allowed fix (15 min, if needed)

- Open master project.
- One adjustment, re-render.
- **Done.** No more passes.

Step 4: Acceptance + release

- Rename final: Project2_RELEASE.wav.
 - If actually releasing: upload to Bandcamp/Soundcloud/Spotify via DistroKid/etc.
 - If not: file it where you won't lose it.
 - Send to a few people.
-

■ Deliverable

- Release-quality master of Project 2.
 - Hits streaming loudness target.
 - Translates across systems.
-

Anti-perfectionism rules

- **Maximum two master passes total.** Session 2 + one Session 3 fix. After that, done.
 - **One mix pass + one mix triage allowed.** No mix rebuilds after Session 2 Step 3.
 - **No referencing after Session 3.** Don't compare next day and feel bad.
 - **The bad first masters are the point.** Master 5–10 tracks before judging your mastering skill.
-

After Week 10

- **Full week off.** Active rest. No M8, no other gear, no browsing.
- Then reflect on the full cycle: what worked, what didn't, what changes for the next cycle.

Mixing Reference

Use this page when balancing tracks against each other — before finalization. Linked from Week 3, Week 5, Week 8, Week 9, Week 10, and the Finalization Reference.

What this is: procedures and checklists for getting from "the elements exist" to "the elements are balanced, clear, and don't fight each other."

What this is NOT: professional mixing. That's a multi-year skill. This is *functional mixing* — reliably getting tracks to a state where finalization can do its job.

Two scopes:

- **Scope A — On-device M8 only.** Default. Mixer View, per-instrument EQ, send levels, TRIG-based side-chain. Used in Weeks 5, 8, 9.
- **Scope B — Render stems to Ableton.** Optional upgrade for tracks you'll publish. Used in Week 10.

The hardest rule of mixing: time-box. 60 min per session, max. If you've been mixing the same track for 3 hours, you've stopped hearing it.

The 5 dimensions of a mix

Mixing is shaping how sounds relate to each other along five axes. Different problems live on different axes — fixing the wrong one wastes time.

Dimension	Problem it solves	Tools on M8
Frequency	Two elements fighting in the same range; mud; harshness	Per-instrument EQ (p.32), main mix EQ
Level	One element too loud or too quiet	Track volume in Mixer View, instrument volume
Space	Mix sounds narrow, flat, or cluttered in the middle	Stereo width on ModFX/Delay/Reverb, instrument pan
Depth	Mix sounds 2D, no foreground/background	Reverb send levels, delay send levels
Dynamics	Kick gets buried by bass; mix feels static or pumpny	TRIG envelope side-chain (p.21), OTT (p.30), per-instrument modulation

Diagnostic question when something sounds wrong: which dimension is the problem? Most mix problems are misdiagnosed as level problems when they're actually frequency or dynamics problems.

The mix order

Always mix from the loudest, lowest, most-important elements first. Don't start with the lead synth and work down — you'll keep redoing everything.

Kick first. Get its volume right against silence. Reference -6dBFS peak.

Bass against kick. This is the most important relationship in the mix. They share frequency space below 200Hz — they MUST share it intentionally, not by accident.

Rest of drums (snare, hats, percussion) as a coherent group. Treat the drums as one element.

Drums vs bass. Does the bass disappear under the drums? Does the kick disappear under the bass? Fix now.

Melodic / harmonic elements (pads, leads, chords). Last priority. They fit around the rhythm section.

Effects / atmosphere. Reverb, delay, FX risers, transitions. Last.

If you go out of order, you mix everything to the lead, then can't hear the kick, then turn up the kick, then re-mix everything.

Scope A: On-device M8 mixing

Manual references: Mixer View (p.30), EQ Editor View (p.32), Effect Settings View (p.36), Instrument Modulation View (p.18), Trig Envelope (p.21).

Tool 1: Track volume (Mixer View)

- Mixer View: [SHIFT]+[DOWN] from Song View.
- Each of 8 tracks has volume.
- Watch the meter — red bars = clipping. Lower offenders.
- Rule: aim for peaks around -6 dBFS on individual tracks. Leaves headroom for limiter.
- Track volume also affects send levels proportionally.

Tool 2: Per-instrument EQ (3-band)

M8 has a 3-band parametric EQ per instrument with 128 shareable EQ banks (manual p.32). This is your primary mix tool.

Access: Instrument View → EQ slot → [SHIFT]+[RIGHT] or [EDIT] to open EQ Editor.

Each band has GAIN, FREQ, Q (bandwidth), TYPE (LOWCUT, LOWSHELF, BELL, BANDPASS, HI.SHELF, HI.CUT, ALLPASS), and MODE (STEREO, MID, SIDE, LEFT, RIGHT).

Frequency carving recipes

Kick: boost around 60–80Hz (body), cut 200–400Hz (mud), boost 3–5kHz if you want click/attack. HI.CUT above 8kHz to leave room for hats.

Bass: LOWCUT below 40Hz (kills subsonic that fights kick). Cut a notch where the kick's body lives (60–80Hz) so they don't pile up. Most bass character lives 80–250Hz.

Snare: boost around 200Hz (body), boost 5kHz (snap/snare wires).

Hi-hats: LOWCUT around 300Hz (removes any bleed/lows). HI.SHELF boost above 8kHz for air.

Lead/melodic: depends on the instrument. Generally LOWCUT below 100–200Hz to keep low end clean for kick/bass.

Pad: carve out 200–500Hz to avoid mud. Pads usually sound better with a slight scoop in the low-mids.

EQ rules

- **Cuts are usually better than boosts.** If two elements fight, cut one rather than boosting the other. Stops the mix getting louder and louder.
- **Wide cuts, narrow boosts.** Low Q for cuts (gentle), higher Q for boosts (surgical).
- **Max 6dB moves.** If you need more, the instrument is wrong, not the mix.
- **EQ in context, not solo.** Soloing an instrument and EQ'ing it sounds great but ignores the mix. Always check in the full mix.

Tool 3: Side-chain via TRIG envelope

The classic "kick ducks bass" effect. Real M8 mechanism (manual p.21, Trig Envelope).

Setup:

- On the bass instrument, go to Instrument Modulation View ([SHIFT]+[UP] from Instrument View).
- Pick an unused MOD slot.
- TYPE: TRIG ENVELOPE
- SRC: set to the kick's instrument number (e.g. 00 if kick is instrument 00), OR 80 + track number for "any instrument on track N" (e.g. 80 = track 1).
- DEST: VOLUME (or AMP).
- AMT: negative value (e.g. -60) — this ducks the bass when the kick triggers.
- ATK: 00 (instant duck).
- HOLD: short (08–10).
- DEC: medium (20–30) — controls how fast the bass comes back.

Result: every time the kick hits, bass ducks. Kick gets through cleanly. Classic side-chain.

Variations:

- Side-chain pads to the kick for breathing/pumping motion.
- Side-chain reverb sends to the lead for clearer dry signal under busy moments.

Tool 4: Send effects as depth (Reverb / Delay)

Front-to-back depth comes from reverb and delay sends, not just from levels.

- Lead vocals/melodies = dry (foreground)
- Snare with medium reverb = mid-ground
- Pad with long reverb + delay = background

Manual: Effect Settings View, p.36–37. Three send effects: ModFX, Delay, Reverb.

- Per-instrument send levels: MFX, DEL, REV in Instrument View.
- Global effect settings: Effect Settings View ([SHIFT]+[DOWN] from Mixer View).

Rule: not everything needs reverb. **Less reverb than you think.** Most amateur mixes drown in reverb.

Tool 5: Stereo width

- Each send effect has a WIDTH parameter (manual p.36): 00 = mono, FF = stereo.
- ModFX (chorus/phaser/flanger) inherently widens.
- Reverb width adds spatial dimension to the wet signal.

General approach:

- Kick, bass, lead vocal/main melody = center, mono-leaning.
- Hats, percussion, secondary elements = wider, off-center.
- Pads, ambient layers = widest.

The full Scope A mix pass

Step-by-step. Target: 30–60 min depending on complexity.

Step 1: Mute everything except kick (5 min)

- Mute all tracks except kick ([OPTION]+[SHIFT] per track).
- Set kick volume to peak around -6 dBFS. Watch the meter.
- EQ kick if needed (see recipe above).

Step 2: Add bass, balance against kick (10 min)

- Unmute bass. Hear them together.
- Set bass volume so kick still cuts through.
- If they fight: EQ. Carve a hole in bass at kick's fundamental, OR roll off bass sub below kick.
- If still fighting: side-chain bass to kick via TRIG envelope.
- **You should hear both the kick AND the bass distinctly. If you don't, fix it now.**

Step 3: Add rest of drums (10 min)

- Unmute snare, hats, perc. Balance against kick + bass.
- EQ for separation: snare body around 200Hz, hat air above 8kHz.
- Check: are the drums a coherent group? Do they swing together?

Step 4: Add melodic elements (15 min)

- Unmute one melodic element at a time. Balance against drums + bass.
- EQ: LOWCUT melodic elements below 100–200Hz to keep low end clean.
- Add reverb/delay sends for depth where appropriate. Less than you think.
- Pan/widen secondary elements.

Step 5: Full-mix check (10 min)

- All tracks unmuted. Listen to full sections.
 - Is anything getting buried? Is anything too loud?
 - **Check on 2 systems:** M8 speakers + headphones, OR phone + headphones.
 - Fix glaring issues. Ignore minor ones.
 - **Stop at 60 min total.**
-

Scope B: Render stems to Ableton

For tracks you'll publish. Used in Week 10.

Stem rendering on M8

Manual: Render View (p.47), Selection to Sample (p.48).

- In Song View, mute all tracks except one.
- Render the song. You get a WAV of just that track.
- Repeat for each of 8 tracks. End up with 8 stems.
- Tip: keep all track effects/EQ as-is on M8 — you're rendering the M8 sound, not raw oscillators.

Minimal Ableton mix

Import all 8 stems on separate audio tracks. Then:

Levels first. Pull all faders down. Bring up kick to peak around -10dBFS. Build the rest against it.

EQ on each stem as needed. Same principles as Scope A: LOWCUT melodic stems, carve frequency space, max 6dB moves.

Bus compression on drum bus (optional). Glue Compressor, 2:1, slow attack, 1–2dB GR. Tightens the drums.

Side-chain via Ableton sends. Use the dedicated side-chain compressor on the bass/pads triggered by the kick stem.

Reference against one professional track. Match perceived balance.

Time-box: 60 min.

Then Master with the Scope B chain (see Finalization Reference).

Reference checking

Same principle as mastering, but at the mix stage:

- Pick one reference track in your genre. Have it on hand.
- A/B between your mix and the reference at matched volumes.
- Ask: where does the kick sit? How loud is the bass relative to the kick? Where are the leads? How dry/wet is the reference?
- Don't try to copy. Try to understand what "normal" looks like in your genre.

Reference tracks (same as Finalization Reference):

- [laamaa — seven weeks](#)
 - [Nullsleep — Lossless Experience](#)
 - [Jeremy Blake — Rituals](#)
-

Anti-perfectionism rules

- **Time-box.** 60 min per mix session. Hard limit.
 - **Listen to full sections, not loops.** Looping a single bar makes everything sound fine.
 - **Don't solo for more than 30 seconds.** Mixes happen in context, not in isolation.
 - **The mix is done when nothing obvious is wrong on 2 systems.** Not when it's perfect.
 - **Bad mixes are how you learn.** Your first 20 mixes will be over-EQ'd, weirdly panned, too dry, or too wet. Ship anyway.
 - **80/20 rule.** Most mix problems are levels and EQ between kick and bass. Get those right and 80% of the mix is done.
-

When mixing fails

Symptoms:

- Track sounds clear on M8 speakers but muddy on headphones → too much low-mid buildup. EQ cuts around 200–400Hz on multiple elements.
- Sounds clear on headphones but thin on speakers → not enough mids. Boost 500Hz–2kHz on snare, lead, or stab elements.
- Kick disappears when everything is playing → either bass is too loud sub-100Hz, or kick lacks click around 3kHz, or you need side-chain.
- Everything sounds smeared / no clarity → too much reverb. Pull all send levels down 50% and re-balance.
- One element keeps poking out no matter what you do → dynamics problem. Try a TRIG envelope or per-instrument volume modulation to tame peaks.

If you can't fix it in a 60-min session, the instrument design is wrong, not the mix. Go back to Instrument View, fix the offending sound (different envelope, different filter, different osc), and re-mix.

Finalization Reference

Use this page at the end of every finished track, **after mixing**. Linked from Week 6, Week 9, and Week 10.

Mix first, master second. If you haven't done a mixing pass yet, go to Mixing Reference first. Mastering can't fix a bad mix.

What this is: a checklist for getting a rendered M8 track from "raw mix" to "clear, balanced, loud enough, not embarrassing on headphones" in 30–60 minutes.

What this is NOT: professional mastering. That's a multi-year skill with reference monitors, treated rooms, and trained ears. This is *finalization* — the basic polish that makes a track listenable.

Two scopes:

- **Scope A — On-device only (M8 mixer + limiter).** Default. Use this for Project 1 and any learning track.
- **Scope B — M8 + minimal Ableton pass.** Optional upgrade for tracks you'll share or publish (Project 2 onwards).

The most important rule: time-box this. If you've been finalizing for over 60 minutes, you're hurting more than helping. Render, walk away.

Scope A: On-device M8 finalization

Manual references: Mixer View (p.30), EQ Editor View (p.32), Limiter & Mix Scope View (p.34), Effect Settings View (p.36), Render View (p.47).

The M8 has a real mastering chain built into the Mixer: track volumes → send effects (ModFX, Delay, Reverb) → OTT compressor → main EQ → Limiter → DJ filter → Main mix volume. Use it.

Step 1: Pre-master mix check (15 min)

This is a quick verification, not a real mix. The real mix should have happened already via the Mixing Reference.

- Play the full track from Song View. Listen all the way through.
- In **Mixer View** ([SHIFT]+[DOWN] from Song View): watch the meter — any red bars mean clipping. Lower offending tracks.
- If you notice major balance issues (bass too loud, kick buried, reverb washing out everything), **stop mastering and do a real mix pass** via Mixing Reference. Don't try to fix mix problems at the master stage.
- If the mix is solid, proceed to Step 2.

Step 2: Main mix EQ (10 min)

- In Mixer View, select EQ and press [SHIFT]+[RIGHT] or [EDIT] to enter EQ Editor View (p.32).
- M8 main mix EQ has 3 bands (LOW, MID, HIGH).

- **High-pass the mix** at the LOW band: TYPE = LOWCUT, FREQ around 30Hz. Removes subsonic rumble that eats limiter headroom.

- **Optional gentle MID adjustments:** if the track sounds boxy (200–400Hz buildup), small cut. If it sounds dull, small high-shelf boost on HIGH band around 8–12kHz.

- **Rule:** max 3dB moves on any band. If you need more, the mix is wrong, not the EQ.

Step 3: OTT compression (5 min)

OTT (Over The Top) is parallel multi-band upward/downward compression. Brings forward quiet stuff, controls loud stuff. Adds polish.

- Mixer View → OTT parameter.

- Bring up slowly from 00. Listen as it engages.

- Target: 20–40 (subtle). Above 60 it gets crushed/lo-fi. Above 80 it starts ducking the main signal (read manual p.30).

- If OTT makes the track sound worse, leave it at 00. Not every track wants OTT.

Step 4: Limiter (5 min)

The limiter prevents clipping and increases perceived loudness.

- In Mixer View, select LIM and press [SHIFT]+[RIGHT] to enter Limiter & Mix Scope View (p.34).

- LIM parameter: start at 40, push up while watching the scope.

- White line on the MIX indicator shows compression activity. **2–4dB of compression on peaks is healthy. 6dB+ is squashing the dynamics.**

- ATK (attack): 20–40 is a safe range. Faster = more aggressive limiting.

- REL (release): 00 = AUTO mode (adaptive). Use AUTO unless you have a reason not to.

- SOFT CLIP: gentle saturation after limiter. Adds warmth/glue. Bring up MIX value to exaggerate — use sparingly.

Step 5: Final check (10 min)

- Listen on **at least two different playback systems**. The M8's built-in speakers count as one (terrible reference, but useful for catching obvious problems). Headphones count as another.

- Listen for: bass too loud/quiet? Vocals/leads buried? Anything harsh or fatiguing? Anything missing on phone speakers?

- If something's clearly wrong, fix it. If it's "could be a little better," leave it. Time-box.

Step 6: Render (5 min)

- Project View → Render (manual p.47).

- Render settings: 44.1kHz, 16-bit or 24-bit WAV. 24-bit if planning Scope B mastering pass; 16-bit if M8-only is the final.

- Save with a clear filename and date.

- **Done. Walk away.**

Scope B: Optional Ableton mastering pass

Use this for Project 2 onward, or any track you'll share/publish. **If you already own Ableton, this isn't new gear.**

Goal: take the M8-rendered WAV and do a minimal mastering pass to hit streaming loudness targets and improve clarity. **30 minutes max.**

Setup

- Import the rendered WAV onto an audio track in a fresh Ableton project. Don't import the M8 project — just the rendered stereo file.
- Add a **reference track** on a second audio track: pick one professional track in a similar genre that you like the sound of. Match output levels by ear before comparing.
- On the master bus, add this chain in order:

The minimal master chain

1. High-pass filter (EQ Eight)

- HP at 30Hz, 24dB/oct slope. Removes inaudible sub that wastes headroom.

2. Bus EQ (EQ Eight)

- Subtle. **Max 2dB moves per band.**
- Common moves: gentle high-shelf boost (8–12kHz, +1–2dB) for air; tiny low-mid cut (200–300Hz, -1dB) if muddy.
- If you need more than this, the mix is wrong.

3. Bus compressor (Glue Compressor)

- Ratio: 2:1 or 4:1
- Attack: 10–30ms (slow enough to let transients through)
- Release: AUTO
- Threshold: aim for 1–3dB of gain reduction on peaks. **No more.**
- Makeup gain: match levels with bypass on/off.

4. Limiter (Ableton's built-in Limiter or any brickwall)

- Ceiling: -1.0 dBTP (gives streaming platforms headroom)
- Threshold: lower until you hit your loudness target
- Release: AUTO or 50ms

5. Loudness target

- **Streaming target: ≈14 LUFS integrated** (Spotify normalizes to -14 LUFS).
- Use Ableton's built-in loudness meter or a free plugin like Youlean Loudness Meter.
- Some genres (drum & bass, hardcore, modern pop) sit louder around -10 to -12 LUFS. Ambient/IDM often sits quieter at -16 to -18 LUFS.

Reference checking

- A/B against the reference track. Toggle between your master and the reference at matched volumes.
- Specific questions to ask:
 - Is my bass louder or quieter than theirs?
 - Is my high end harsher or duller?
 - Does my master sound thin or full compared?
 - Where is my low-mid sitting?
- Adjust your chain to close the gap. **Don't try to match perfectly.** Match "close enough."

Final render

- Render to stereo WAV, 44.1kHz, 16-bit (or 24-bit if archiving).
 - Listen to the rendered file (not the live Ableton playback) on multiple systems one more time.
 - **Render once. Don't do a second pass.** Time-box.
-

Anti-perfectionism rules

- **Master once.** No second passes. No "let me just tweak the high end one more time."
 - **Time-box.** Scope A = 60 min max. Scope B = 30 min max on top of A.
 - **Three-system check, then done.** If it sounds reasonable on headphones, laptop speakers, and phone, it's mastered. Stop.
 - **No reference comparison after the 30 minutes is up.** Reference checking is for during the process, not for second-guessing after.
 - **Bad mastering is fine.** Your first 10 mastered tracks will be over-compressed, over-EQ'd, or under-loud. That's the only way to learn.
 - **The mix matters more than the master.** If a master sounds wrong, 80% of the time the mix is the problem. Go back to the M8 and fix the mix, don't compensate at the master.
-

Reference tracks to A/B against

Pick one in your target genre and use it consistently. Examples from the M8 community:

- [laamaa — seven weeks](#) (downtempo electronic, M8)
 - [Nullsleep — Lossless Experience](#) (chiptune-adjacent)
 - [Jeremy Blake — Rituals](#) (ambient electronic)
 - For broader electronic references, pick any commercially mastered track on Bandcamp/streaming in the genre you're targeting.
-

What to do when finalization fails

Sometimes a track just won't master well. Symptoms:

- Can't get it loud without crushing it
- Sounds great on headphones, dies on phone speakers (= no mids)
- Sounds great on phone, mush on headphones (= no high detail)
- One element keeps poking out no matter what you do

This is a mix problem, not a master problem. Don't fight it at the master. Go back to the M8 and:

- Re-balance the levels in Mixer View
- Fix the EQ on the offending instrument (Instrument EQ, p.32)
- Tame the offending instrument's send levels
- Re-render, try again

If after one mix fix it still won't master, **render it as-is and move on.** Bad finished tracks teach more than great unfinished ones.

Generative Toolkit Reference

The M8 has a family of generative features. They serve different musical purposes — they're not interchangeable. This page documents each one with a concrete recipe, a clear use case, and the most common failure mode.

Strategy: if a generative feature isn't clicking, you're probably using it for the wrong use case. Match the technique to the goal.

Manual references: Phrase View shortcuts (p.15), LFO modulation type (p.20–21), Table View + TIC modes (p.24), Hypersynth (p.60).

1. Phrase View randomization (selection mode)

Use case: You have a hi-hat or percussion pattern that feels too rigid. You want humanization without writing every variation by hand.

Recipe:

- In Phrase View, position cursor over the notes you want to vary.
- Enter selection mode: [SHIFT]+[OPTION].
- Make sure the **note column** is selected (not velocity/instrument/FX).
- Apply one of:
 - [OPTION]+[UP or DOWN] — randomize note value up or down
 - [OPTION]+[LEFT] — cycle through note fill modes
 - [OPTION]+[RIGHT] — randomize note AND instrument triggers
- Exit selection mode. The result is now committed to the phrase.
- **If you don't like it:** immediately paste ([SHIFT]+[EDIT]) to undo the fill action.

Common failure mode: Trying to randomize the volume or FX columns instead of the note column. The fill modes only work on the note column. Other columns just navigate normally with those keys.

When to reach for it: end of a writing session, when patterns feel locked. 30 seconds of randomization vs 10 minutes of manual variation.

2. Random / Drunk LFO shapes

Use case: You want filter movement (or any modulation) that never repeats exactly the same way. Evolving textures, pads that breathe, sound design that doesn't loop predictably.

Two distinct shapes:

- **RANDOM** — each LFO cycle picks a new random value. Stepped, unpredictable, jumpy.
- **DRUNK** — random walk. Each new value is a small offset from the previous one. Smoother, organic, never returns exactly.

Recipe — evolving pad:

■ Open a pad instrument. Go to Instrument Modulation View ([SHIFT]+[UP] from Instrument View).

■ Set MOD2 (keep MOD1 for envelope):

- TYPE: LFO
- DEST: FILTER CUTOFF
- OSC: DRUNK
- TRIG: FREE (keep walking across notes)
- FREQ: slow (try 20–40)
- AMT: moderate (30–50)

■ Hold a note. The filter wanders.

■ Try the same with OSC: RANDOM. Hear the difference: jumpy vs continuous.

Tick-rate variants: add T to the shape (RANDOM T, DRUNK T). Frequency now runs in ticks instead of 16th notes — much faster modulation, useful for textural sound design rather than slow movement.

Common failure mode: Setting AMT too high. Random/Drunk at high amounts sounds chaotic. Subtle (20–40) is usually better than dramatic.

When to reach for it: anywhere a static parameter should feel alive — filter, pitch (subtle vibrato that wanders), volume (organic dynamics), pan (drifting stereo image).

3. Probability and fill modes (combined with randomization)

Use case: "Every 4th time the pattern loops, maybe the snare has an extra ghost note." Subtle per-cycle variation without manual programming.

Recipe:

The M8's probability mechanism lives partly in Phrase View selection mode (see #1 above) and partly via FX commands you find in the in-device **Effect Command Help view** ([EDIT]+[UP or DOWN] on any FX column).

■ Open Effect Command Help. Browse for probability-related commands available for your instrument type.

■ The commands available depend on instrument type — the help view is the source of truth.

■ Alternative approach: use the note-fill randomization from #1 on duplicate copies of your pattern, then use chain transpose / phrase variation to alternate between them.

Common failure mode: Expecting one universal probability command. The M8 has multiple ways to get probabilistic behavior depending on instrument type and what you're trying to vary. Use the Effect Command Help view to discover what's available right now.

When to reach for it: late-stage humanization, when arrangement is locked but patterns still feel too predictable.

4. Table TIC modes (note/velocity/octave mapping)

This is where tables stop being "step sequencers" and become "input-responsive instruments."

Use case: "I want the same instrument slot to play different sounds depending on which note I trigger, or how hard I trigger it, or what octave I'm in."

Manual: Table TIC Modes, p.24.

- TIC00 — increments table row each time the instrument is triggered (one row per note hit)
- TIC01 TO TICFB — standard tick-per-row playback
- TICFC — **Octave Map**: maps playing octave to table row
- TICFD — **Velocity Map**: maps velocity to table row
- TICFE — **Note Map**: maps note value to table row (use HOP00 on row 0C to limit to 12 notes/octave)
- TICFF — increments at 200Hz (super fast)

Recipe — velocity-mapped drum hits:

- Set up a Sampler instrument. Load one drum sample.
- In Instrument View, set TABLE TIC to TICFD (velocity map).
- Enter the instrument's table. Each row now corresponds to a velocity range.
- In row 00: leave default (lowest velocity)
- In row 04: add a PIT command to slightly pitch up (medium velocity, slight up-pitch)
- In row 08: pitch up more + slight volume boost
- In row 0C: pitch up significantly + add reverb send via FX command
- Now varying velocity on this drum produces actual variations, not just volume changes.

Recipe — note-mapped sample kit:

- Set TABLE TIC to TICFE (note map).
- Add HOP00 on row 0C to limit to 12 notes/octave (per manual instructions).
- Each row of the table now corresponds to a note. Use INS commands (or instrument-changing FX commands) per row to play different sounds per note.
- Result: one "instrument" slot, but plays a drum kit mapped to notes.

Common failure mode: Forgetting to set the TABLE TIC mode. The table works normally until you change TIC to one of the special FC/FD/FE values. Without that, none of the input mapping happens.

When to reach for it: building instruments that respond expressively to playing input. Critical for finger-drum-style kits and for sample chains.

5. Hypersynth

Use case: You want musical chord progressions or scale-aware playback without writing every voice individually. Built for harmonic content (pads, ambient, chord stabs).

Manual: Hypersynth, p.60. The Hypersynth section is dense — budget 30 min to explore it on its own.

General approach (verify exact parameters in-device):

- Set an instrument's TYPE to Hypersynth.
- Hypersynth uses the project's Scale (Scale View, p.28) and supports the SCG global scale command.
- Explore the instrument-level parameters via Instrument View — chord type, voicing, scale degree.
- Play a single note in Phrase View. Hypersynth generates the chord around that note based on its settings.

Common failure mode: Treating Hypersynth like Wavsynth/Macrosynth. It's a different model — you're not picking a wave shape, you're configuring chord generation. If a Hypersynth note sounds like a single tone instead of a chord, the chord parameters aren't set up.

When to reach for it: ambient/harmonic tracks where you want progressions without programming every voice. Also great for stab/chord instruments in dancier music.

6. Tables as arpeggiators / generative sequencers

Use case: One note in Phrase View should trigger an evolving phrase — arpeggio, melodic riff, or sequence of pitches/effects that plays automatically.

This is what tables were designed for. Per the manual (p.24): "Tables are little sequencers that play alongside instruments... an incredibly powerful tool to transform instruments and compositions, from arpeggios and volume slides to multi-stage envelopes and effects."

Recipe — generative arpeggio:

- On a melodic instrument, set TABLE TIC to a low tick value like 02 or 04 (faster table playback than the phrase).
- Enter the instrument's table.
- In the N (transpose) column, write a sequence of values: 00, 04, 07, 0C, 07, 04, 00, -05 (this is a major-7th-up arp and back).
- In Phrase View, trigger ONE note on this instrument. The table plays the arp.
- Use HOP commands in the table to loop a subsection or jump around — creates evolving rather than just-repeating arps.

Recipe — polyrhythmic interest:

- On a second instrument's table, do the same but with a DIFFERENT number of rows (use HOP00 to loop after, say, row 7 instead of 16).
- Trigger both instruments simultaneously in the phrase. The two arps loop at different rates, creating polyrhythms.

Common failure mode: Setting TABLE TIC too slow. If TIC matches the phrase tick rate, the table feels like just a constant note, not a sequence. Set it 2–4x faster than phrase rate for arp-feel.

When to reach for it: generative melody composition. Write fewer notes in Phrase View, let the table generate the rest. Excellent for IDM, ambient, generative-leaning electronic music.

Combining techniques

The power comes from combining these, not using them in isolation:

- **Random LFO + Table TIC** — a velocity-mapped drum with Drunk LFO on filter cutoff. Every hit is slightly different, and the filter wanders independently.
- **Hypersynth + Generative table** — Hypersynth provides chord content, table provides chord-stab rhythm pattern.
- **Selection-mode randomization + probability-driven table** — randomize note positions, then have tables generate variations on each note hit.

Discipline: don't combine more than 2 techniques per instrument. Combining 4 gives you sonic chaos that you can't reason about when something sounds wrong.

When generative tools backfire

- **Track has no identity.** You delegated all the writing to randomness; nothing has authorial voice. Fix: keep the chorus/hook deliberate, use generative only for variation/fills.
 - **Can't reproduce a sound you liked.** Random shapes don't seed deterministically. Fix: when you find a good random pattern, freeze it by rendering to sample (Selection to Sample, p.48) and using the sample instead.
 - **Patterns feel "twitchy."** Too much randomization. Fix: lower the LFO AMT, reduce probability density, use Drunk instead of Random.
 - **Sounds great in isolation, terrible in mix.** Generative elements competing for the same frequency space. Fix: mix discipline (see Mixing Reference) applies to generative elements too.
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How to learn this set

Don't try to learn all 6 techniques in one sitting. The plan weaves them into specific weeks:

- **Week 2** — Random/Drunk LFO shapes (extension of LFO learning)
- **Week 4** — Phrase randomization + probability (extension of pattern variation)
- **Week 7** — Table TIC modes (FC/FD/FE) + Hypersynth (library week, no track pressure)
- **Week 8** — Tables as arpeggiators (use as melodic shortcut for Project 2)

After the plan: revisit this page and combine. The combinations are where the M8 gets uniquely powerful.

About this document

This plan was built collaboratively between a producer and Claude (Anthropic) over an extended conversation. The producer brought the gear history, the personal weaknesses, the priorities, and the corrections. Claude pulled references from the M8 manual (firmware 6.5.2) and the awesome-m8 community list, structured the plan into phases and weeks, and helped enforce time-boxes and anti-perfectionism rules.

It's been generalized for sharing. The structure is real; the framing is real; the anti-perfectionism rules are real. The personal details have been removed.

License: free to share, adapt, remix. If it helps you finish tracks, that's the point.

Credit: Built collaboratively with Claude (Anthropic). M8 by Dirtywave (Timothy Lamb).

If you build a track using this plan, consider sharing it back to the M8 community. The point isn't the plan, it's finished music.